UNIT 2 · CHAPTER 8 · A HOUSE DIVIDED

A New Birth of Freedom

The war's bloodiest years, its turning points, and the freedom written at last into the Constitution. 1863–1865.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

The war's bloodiest years, its turning points, and the freedom written at last into the Constitution. 1863–1865.

What finally broke the Confederacy — and what did victory cost?

The Hinge of the War

JULY 1863

In a single week, the war turned. At Gettysburg, Lee's invasion of the North was stopped in three days of the bloodiest fighting the continent had ever seen. The very next day, far to the west, Vicksburg surrendered.

Vicksburg gave the Union the whole Mississippi River and split the Confederacy in two. After that first week of July, the South would never again come so close to winning.

"Siege of Vicksburg, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Tide Turns

1863–1865

Four blows — Gettysburg, Vicksburg, Atlanta, Appomattox — that broke the Confederacy.

The turning points of 1863–1865. Gettysburg and Vicksburg (July 1863) stopped the South; Atlanta (1864) and Appomattox (1865) finished it. · Map © ShadowDog Digital Studios

Grant Takes Command

1864

Lincoln had spent three years searching for a general who would fight. In Ulysses S. Grant, he finally found one. Grant came east and launched the Overland Campaign — the Wilderness, Spotsylvania, Cold Harbor.

The losses were staggering, and critics called him a butcher. But Grant understood the brutal arithmetic: the Union could replace its armies and the South could not. He would not retreat, and he would not let Lee recover.

"Battle of Lookout Mountain, November 24, 1863" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

Atlanta and the Election

SEPTEMBER 1864

By mid-1864 the North was war-weary, and it looked as if voters might turn Lincoln out for a peace candidate who would let the South go. Then William Tecumseh Sherman captured Atlanta.

The victory electrified the North and may well have saved Lincoln's reelection — and with it, the war's unfinished purpose. A battlefield had just decided a ballot box.

General Grant's "Council of War" at Massaponax Church, Virginia — photograph, May 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

A Democracy Votes Mid-War

NOVEMBER 1864

No nation had ever stopped in the middle of a civil war to hold a free election — and risked voting its leader out. The United States did.

Lincoln won decisively, and Union soldiers, who could have voted to go home, instead voted overwhelmingly to see the war through. The result was a mandate to win and to end slavery for good.

"Battle of Atlanta, July 22, 1864" — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

A New Kind of War

GEORGIA, LATE 1864

From Atlanta, Sherman cut loose and marched his army to the sea at Savannah, living off the land and destroying everything of military value — railroads, mills, crops, homes — in a sixty-mile-wide path.

This was total war: aimed not just at the South's armies but at its will and ability to fight. It helped end the war faster — and it is remembered in the South with bitterness to this day.

"The Dictator" — a 13-inch mortar on a railroad car before Petersburg, Virginia — photograph, 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

The Long Siege

1864–1865

In Virginia, Grant pinned Lee's army at Petersburg, the rail hub that kept Richmond alive. For nine months the two armies faced each other across miles of trenches, mines, and barbed obstacles.

It was grinding, static, and deadly — a grim preview of the trench warfare that would horrify the world fifty years later. Slowly, the Confederacy starved.

"The Surrender of General Lee, April 9, 1865" — lithograph, public domain (Library of Congress).

ABRAHAM LINCOLN · SECOND INAUGURAL, MARCH 1865

With malice toward none, with charity for all … let us strive on to finish the work we are in, to bind up the nation's wounds.

Appomattox

APRIL 9, 1865

Surrounded, outnumbered, and starving, Lee surrendered to Grant at Appomattox Court House in Virginia. Grant's terms were strikingly generous: Confederate soldiers were paroled and sent home, allowed to keep their horses for the spring planting.

There were no mass arrests, no executions. After four years and three-quarters of a million dead, the war was ending the way Lincoln had hoped — in mercy.

“The Triumph of Freedom over Slavery” — print with the text of the Thirteenth Amendment and the roll of ayes, public domain (Library of Congress).

Five Days Later

APRIL 14, 1865

The mercy did not last the week. On Good Friday, at Ford's Theatre in Washington, the actor John Wilkes Booth shot President Lincoln. He died the next morning.

The man who had spoken of “malice toward none” would not live to guide the peace. A grieving nation's mood hardened — and the hardest questions of all still lay ahead.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

Freedom in the Constitution

DECEMBER 1865

The thing the whole war had circled was finally written into the nation's highest law. The Thirteenth Amendment abolished slavery everywhere in the United States, forever — not by proclamation, which a court or a later president might undo, but by the Constitution itself.

Slavery was dead. But what freedom would actually mean for four million people was a question the war had not answered — and that was the next, unfinished fight.

“Siege of Vicksburg, 1863” — chromolithograph, Kurz & Allison, public domain (Library of Congress).

Eleven Investigations

YOUR TURN

From the hinge at Gettysburg to the freedom written into the Constitution — eleven deep dives into the war's decisive years, all now live.